Photographs by HARDIK CHHABRA



NANDITA DAS | 55 |
Actress and director

"Why describe me by the colour of my skin?"

When I am written about, I am often described as 'dark and dusky'. I don't object at all. I am all for calling a spade a spade. In fact, dark doesn't need to be even softened to dusky! All I wonder is why there is a need to describe me through the colour of my skin, as I hope there is more to me! Or is it simply because it is rather rare for a female actor to be dark and therefore it becomes imperative to make a point about it.

Any person's complexion is only one of their many features or characteristics and therefore to give it undue importance would be to do injustice to the person. That's all.

IN

21st century India, it does not matter that you are a woman who has broken the glass ceiling. Just a stray, unfeeling comment can transport you back to a place of insecurity that you thought you had left far behind. A time when the darker shade of your skin put you in the shadows, unseen, unheard and unwanted. Sarada Muraleedharan was in that place recently. Courtesy a careless remark thrown at her about her tenure as Kerala chief secretary being as black as her husband's was white, the black labelling bearing "the quiet subtext of being a woman". Long inured to the casual colourism she had encountered all her life, Sarada decided to "call this one out" on a Facebook post simply because of the speaker's implied equivalence of black with "the ne'er do good, black the malaise, the cold despotism, the heart of darkness".

The eloquent post reopened an old wound as it were and reignited the debate about the ugly, unfair prejudice Indians continue to harbour against someone dark of skin. A whole sea of condemnation erupted on mainstream and social media in response to Sarada's post, with hashtags like #Unfair&Lovely beginning to trend widely, challenging the norm, and celebrating darker skin tones. The actress Kani Kusruti, who left a lasting impression with her performance in Payal Kapadia's *All We Imagine as Light*, the first Indian film to win a Grand Prix award at Cannes, wrote an impassioned column in a leading daily, talking of how, even as a child, her relatives asked her to wear only light-coloured clothes because "if you wear black or any other dark shade, we can't see you". There is a hierarchy of colour, she went on to